

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

Cosmetic Surgery



As a hug-and-make-up gift maybe Harbhajan Singh and S. Sreesanth should present each other stone tablets engraved with the first Law of Brattishness, as formulated by a baseball coach: "The bigger the pain in the a** you are, the bigger your game had better be". Obviously, the two petulant, problem children of the moment have some distance to go in the game department, the fast bowler further so than the spinner.

The BCCI have been vehement in their desire to clamp down on player misbehaviour, but is this to be a long-delayed consistent policy? Or is it just cosmetic surgery the IPL came up with to make sure that nothing sullied its image as a serious competition with serious rules, not an operation where rules up are made up as it goes along. (Perhaps we just should ask the franchises.)

It is now evident that under the guise of this entity repeatedly and tiresomely called "fearless, young India", all lines of conduct are being treated as mere patterns in the sand, easily trod upon on the most feeble of pretexts. Like, Indians have finally learnt the art of 'aggression'. Or feebler still, that the game needs "characters". The triumphalistic behaviour of the India under-19s moments after winning the junior World Cup was enough proof of how far this self-perpetuating syndrome has gone.

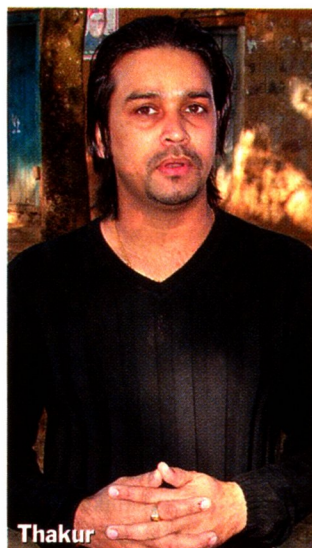
The ban on Harbhajan was needed because he had reached the end of his rope. In a far shorter span of time, so has Sreesanth who, instead of being known as the outswing king, is now famous for being the 'drama queen' of the Indian team. His welcome into the Indian dressing room when the team reconvenes is bound to be frosty. Claiming victimisation on grounds of being the 'lone Malayalee' (as he is alleged to have said to a Malayalam TV channel) will only convince the truly one-eyed.

A growing preference for showmanship over substance amongst young cricketers is easily explained by a former India cricketer who laughs, "It's a lot tougher to come into the limelight by scoring runs or getting wickets, isn't it?" Former fast bowler Javagal Srinath, now an ICC match referee, says that through his career every cricketer carries a character certificate. The importance of having a clean one, he says has to be imparted at the grassroots, at state and junior levels, "on a war footing".

He is not overreacting. "Young fearless India" is failing Indian cricket. It consistently gives out terrible, scrambled messages. What else would explain Aussie Adam Gilchrist being given a "send-off" at the Eden Gardens during an IPL match by a boy no older than 12?



SAURABH SINGH



Thakur



Sangma

The K Factor for Polls

CHANDIGARH For the kin of politicians, the bypolls are often a safe bet to launch themselves into the political arena. No wonder then that dynastic politics takes over in the upcoming byelections to two parliamentary and four Assembly seats in Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh and Meghalaya. For the Hamirpur Lok Sabha seat, BJP has fielded Anurag Thakur, son of Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal who had vacated his seat for the top post in the state.

In distant Meghalaya, Nationalist Congress Party leader and former Lok Sabha Speaker P.A. Sangma has warmed his pocketborough, Tura parliamentary segment, which he has represented for a record nine times since 1977, for his daughter, Agatha K. Sangma. She will be the party's candidate for the by-election necessitated by Sangma's election to the Assembly. Both his sons have also made it to the state Assembly, with one billed as "one of the most

powerful" ministers in the Meghalaya Cabinet.

In Punjab, the ruling Shiromani Akali Dal has fielded Inderbir Singh, a political greenhorn and son of deceased MLA Raminder Singh Bolaria, as its candidate for the Amritsar-South Assembly segment. In neighbouring Haryana, where three Assembly seats are up for grabs in the wake of disqualification of three breakaway Congress MLAs of the newly-floated Haryana Janhit Congress led by former chief minister Bhajan Lal and his son and MP Kuldip Bishnoi, the Congress has put up Ranjit Singh—brother of former chief minister and Indian National Lok Dal supremo Om Prakash Chautala—from the prestigious Adampur segment against Lal. Bishnoi, a rebel Congress MP from Bhiwani, opted out in favour of his father at the eleventh hour as the party's chief campaigner at all three Assembly seats. Clearly, political kin have a lot at stake in the bypolls. **by Ramesh Vinayak**